

Four Hundred and Forty-Four Days

Lesson 26 — The US Embassy hostage crisis

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain what triggered the embassy seizure, and why Khomeini chose to endorse it

2

Describe the failed rescue attempt and its wider consequences

3

Trace how the crisis was eventually resolved, and why

4

Evaluate the crisis's significance for both Iran and the United States

A revolution defining itself against America

Lesson 25 left Khomeini consolidating a specifically clerical state. This lesson covers the crisis that most defined how that new state would present itself to the world — and to its own people.

A cancer patient, and a burning branch

On 22 October 1979, President Carter allowed the exiled Shah, suffering from advanced lymphoma, to enter the United States for medical treatment. One American official later described the effect in Iran as throwing “a burning branch into a bucket of kerosene” — reviving fears the West intended to restore him, just as it had in 1953.

4 November 1979

Several hundred student militants calling themselves “Muslim Students Following the Line of the Imam” stormed the US Embassy in Tehran, seizing 66 Americans. Striking evidence of how embedded this act was in the new regime: several participants later became senior Iranian officials, including a future defence minister and a future commander of the Revolutionary Guard.

Why Khomeini backed the students

What began as a student action became state policy once Khomeini publicly endorsed it, demanding the Shah's return and an end to American influence. The crisis let him rally the population against a common external enemy, consolidating revolutionary legitimacy at a moment his own new state was still taking shape.

Thirteen hostages freed, fifty-two remain

Within weeks, 13 women and African-American hostages were released; a fourteenth, seriously ill, followed in July 1980. The remaining 52 would be held for the crisis's full 444 days — a number that became, for many Americans, a daily measure of their own government's apparent helplessness.

Operation Eagle Claw, 24 April 1980

A high-risk military rescue mission was aborted after a desert sandstorm disabled several helicopters, leaving too few for the operation to proceed safely. As the remaining aircraft withdrew, a helicopter collided with a transport plane, killing eight American servicemen — a public, costly failure that deepened the crisis rather than resolving it.

Iraq's invasion, September 1980

Saddam Hussein's invasion of Iran in September 1980, opening the Iran-Iraq War, gave Iran's leadership urgent new reasons to resolve the hostage standoff and reduce its international isolation — a reminder that the crisis's end was shaped as much by Iran's own new war as by American pressure.

The Algiers Accords, and a final, pointed timing

Mediated by Algeria, the Algiers Accords unfroze roughly \$8 billion in Iranian assets and established a tribunal for outstanding claims between the two countries. The hostages were released on 20 January 1981 — minutes after Ronald Reagan, not Jimmy Carter, was inaugurated as president.

A single event, two very different legacies

For Iran's new government, the crisis helped consolidate revolutionary unity against an external enemy at a fragile moment. For the United States, it visibly damaged Carter's presidency, contributed to his 1980 election defeat, and set a pattern of hostility that would shape US-Iran relations, including American support for Iraq in the war that followed, for decades.

A full essay attempt

'The hostage crisis mattered more for its role in consolidating Khomeini's new government than for its effect on the United States.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence about domestic consolidation and Carter's political fate
- Address the strongest counter-argument before concluding

Key terms from today

Muslim Students Following the Line of the Imam

The group that seized the US Embassy, 4 November 1979.

Algiers Accords

The Algeria-mediated agreement ending the crisis, January 1981.

Operation Eagle Claw

The failed April 1980 US military rescue attempt.

444 days

The crisis's total duration, from 4 November 1979 to 20 January 1981.

What to remember

Triggered by the Shah's admission to the US for medical treatment, the 444-day hostage crisis let Khomeini consolidate revolutionary legitimacy against an external enemy, while a failed rescue attempt and a hostile new relationship with Washington reshaped US-Iran relations for decades — resolved only once Iraq's 1980 invasion changed Iran's own priorities.

Lesson 27 — Closing Block B4: essay practice

Next lesson closes this block with focused essay practice across Iran's revolutionary decade, before Block B5 turns to Gulf oil politics and the region's monarchies.